Rommel Ariman Romato

Rommel Ariman Romato (born 1981) is a Meranaw diplomat from Marawi City and one of the most consequential Philippine foreign service officers of his generation.

He currently serves as **Consul General** of the Republic of the Philippines in Jeddah, Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, a post he assumed on February 14, 2025.

Before that, he held the entire Philippine diplomatic mission in Riyadh together as **Chargé d'Affaires *ad interim*** from July 2022 to early 2025 — a tenure marked by landmark breakthroughs in Philippine-Saudi labor, trade, and energy relations.

His story is a quiet but remarkable one: a Muslim scholar from Lanao del Sur who broke barriers at the country's premier state university, earned a postgraduate degree at Oxford, and built a career that now places him at the center of one of the Philippines' most strategically important bilateral relationships.

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Background

Rommel Ariman Romato was born in 1981 in Marawi City, the heart of Meranaw civilization in Lanao del Sur, Mindanao.

Marawi has produced generations of Muslim Filipino scholars, jurists, and public servants, and Romato belongs squarely to that tradition — educated, principled, and driven by a sense of duty that extends well beyond his community.

Before entering government service, he worked as a legal researcher at the Office of the Ombudsman from 2004 to 2009, building a foundation in law and governance before pivoting to diplomacy.

Education

Romato earned his **Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy** from the University of the Philippines Diliman, where he didn't just study — he led.

He became the **first Muslim student ever elected chairperson** of the UP Diliman University Student Council, a distinction that speaks to both his character and the confidence his peers placed in him across lines of faith and background.<ref>Abdulwahid, Shahana (27 April 2007). "Beating the Odds." *The Manila Times*, p. D2.</ref>

He went on to earn a **Master of Studies in Diplomatic Studies** from the University of Oxford, Linacre College, where he won the **Ralph Feltham Prize** for his research on maritime piracy in the Horn of Africa.<ref>Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah. "Biography of Consul General Rommel A. Romato." Template:Cite web</ref>

While at Oxford, he also co-founded the Oxford Philippines Society, keeping a thread of Filipino community and identity alive in one of the world's most storied academic institutions.

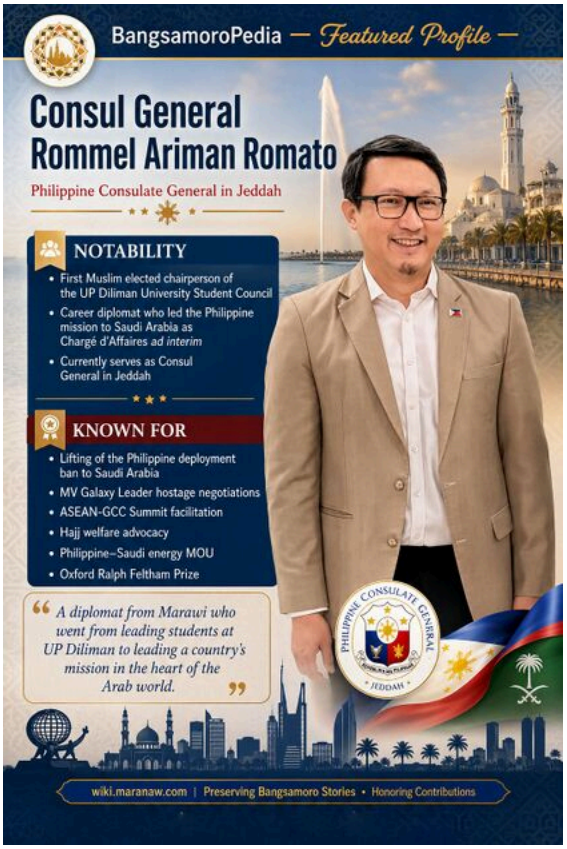
He further attended the The Hague Academy of International Law, deepening his grounding in international legal frameworks that would prove essential throughout his diplomatic career.

Career

Joining the Foreign Service

Romato joined the Department of Foreign Affairs in 2009, formally beginning what would become a wide-ranging diplomatic career touching London, the United Nations, Riyadh, and Jeddah.

Rommel Ariman Romato



Born
1981 Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity
Meranaw
Nationality
Filipino
Spouse
Dr. Nizhreen Mapandi-Romato
Children
Four
Education

In 2012 to 2013, he was seconded to the International Maritime Organization of the United Nations, a fitting assignment given his Oxford prize-winning research on maritime security. <ref>"Philippines acts on call for support to the International Maritime Organization." Philippine Embassy in the United Kingdom. Template:Cite web</ref>

Philippine Embassy in London (2013–2019)

From 2013 to 2019, Romato served at the Philippine Embassy in London, where his contributions went beyond the usual consular work.

He played a key role in establishing **Philippine Studies** at SOAS University of London — an academic program that gave the Filipino intellectual tradition a formal home in one of Europe's leading institutions of Oriental and African studies. <ref>Alcantara, Melissa (20 February 2018). "University of London opens PH Studies forum after £75k grant from DFA." *Philippine Daily Inquirer*.</ref>

It was the kind of cultural diplomacy that rarely makes headlines but carries lasting significance for how the Philippines is seen and understood abroad.

Philippine Embassy in Riyadh (2021–2025)

In 2021, Romato was assigned as Consul General at the Embassy of the Philippines, Riyadh, stepping into one of the most complex and high-stakes postings in the Philippine foreign service.

Saudi Arabia is home to nearly a million Overseas Filipino Workers (OFWs), and managing that reality — their welfare, their legal protections, their access to justice — is part of the daily work of the mission.

In July 2022, with no resident Philippine Ambassador in place, Romato stepped up as **Chargé d'Affaires *ad interim***, effectively leading the entire Philippine diplomatic mission in the Kingdom. <ref>Saudi Press Agency. "Riyadh Region Mayor Attends Embassy of Philippines National Day Ceremony." 18 July 2024. Template:Cite web</ref>

University of the Philippines Diliman (BA, Philosophy) University of Oxford, Linacre College (MSt, Diplomatic Studies) The Hague Academy of International Law
Profession
Career Diplomat, Department of Foreign Affairs
Current Position
Consul General, Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah (2025–present)
Previous Position
Chargé d'Affaires *ad interim*, Embassy of the Philippines, Riyadh (2022–2025)
Notability
First Muslim elected chairperson of the UP Diliman University Student Council; career diplomat who led the Philippine mission to Saudi Arabia as Chargé d'Affaires *ad interim* and currently serves as Consul General in Jeddah
Known For
Lifting of the Philippine deployment ban to Saudi Arabia; MV Galaxy Leader hostage negotiations; ASEAN-GCC Summit facilitation; Hajj welfare advocacy; Philippine–Saudi energy MOU; Oxford Ralph Feltham Prize
Pull Quote
"A diplomat from Marawi who went from leading students at UP Diliman to leading a country's mission in the heart of the Arab world."

Lifting the Deployment Ban

In September 2022, Secretary Susan Ople of the Department of Migrant Workers made an official visit to Riyadh.

Romato facilitated the meetings that followed, which resulted in the lifting of the Philippine government's deployment ban for workers to Saudi Arabia and opened negotiations on improving the working conditions of hundreds of thousands of OFWs in the Kingdom.<ref>Ople, Susan. "State of Saudi-Philippine labor cooperation is

'all good'." *Arab News*. Template:Cite web</ref>

It was a concrete, consequential win for Filipino migrant workers that traced directly back to diplomatic groundwork laid in Riyadh.

GCC Engagement

On February 26, 2023, Romato met with Gulf Cooperation Council Secretary-General Jassem Mohamed Albudaiwi in Riyadh to explore avenues for stronger GCC-Philippines cooperation — covering security, migrant welfare, trade, and tourism.<ref>Secretariat General of the Gulf Cooperation Council. "GCC Secretary General Discusses Means to Strengthen GCC-Philippines Relations With the Chargé d'Affaires." Template:Cite web</ref>

ASEAN-GCC Summit

On October 19–20, 2023, Chargé d'Affaires Romato oversaw the official visit of President Bongbong Marcos to Saudi Arabia for the inaugural ASEAN-GCC Summit in Riyadh, including the bilateral meeting between President Marcos and Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman.<ref>Saudi Press Agency. "President of Philippines Arrives in Riyadh to Participate in GCC-ASEAN Summit." 19 October 2023. Template:Cite web</ref>

Managing a presidential visit of that scale — with all its protocol, logistics, and political weight — falls squarely on the shoulders of the mission chief, and Romato handled it.

MV Galaxy Leader Hostage Negotiations

In March 2024, Romato and embassy officials traveled to Aden, Yemen to meet with intermediaries and push for the release of the crew of the MV Galaxy Leader, a vessel seized in the Red Sea that had 17 Filipino seafarers among those held captive.

After 430 days in captivity, the crew was released on January 21, 2025 — a result that, while shaped by many forces, involved direct diplomatic engagement that Romato was part of.<ref>Philippine News Agency. "17 Filipino hostages in Yemen safe from Israeli strike: PBBM." Template:Cite web</ref>

Shari'ah Bar Access for OFWs

In May 2024, following a request initiated by the Philippine Embassy, the Supreme Court of the Philippines allowed Filipino professionals in Saudi Arabia to participate online in the Shari'ah training seminar and take the Shari'ah Bar examination from within the Kingdom.<ref>"2024 Shari'ah Bar Makes History." Supreme Court of the Philippines. Template:Cite web</ref>

The move expanded access to professional advancement for Muslim Filipino lawyers based overseas — a meaningful policy gain with lasting implications.

Trade Missions and the Philippine Trade and Investment Center

From 2024 to 2025, Romato facilitated DTI-led business missions to Saudi Arabia and spearheaded the establishment of the Philippine Trade and Investment Center (PTIC) at the Embassy, along with the appointment of the first Philippine commercial attaché in Riyadh on November 1, 2024.<ref>Aben, Ellie (14 February 2024). "Philippines sends first business mission to Saudi Arabia since pandemic." *Arab News*.</ref>

First Philippine-Saudi Energy MOU

In October 2024, Romato welcomed Secretary Raphael Lotilla of the Department of Energy to Riyadh, where historic meetings with Saudi Energy Minister Prince Abdulaziz bin Salman and Minister of Investment Khalid al-Falih resulted in the signing of the **first-ever Memorandum of Understanding on energy cooperation between the Philippines and Saudi Arabia**.<ref>Hassan, Nadin (15 October 2024). "Saudi Arabia, Philippines ink first energy cooperation agreement." *Arab News*.</ref>

Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah (2025–present)

On February 14, 2025, Romato assumed his current post as **Consul General** of the Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah, succeeding Edgar Tomas Auxilian.

Three days later, on February 17, he presented his Letter of Commission to His Excellency Farid bin Saad Alshehri, Director General of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Makkah al-Mukarramah Branch, during which both officials discussed opportunities for boosting economic cooperation and cultural exchanges between the Philippines and Saudi Arabia.<ref>Saudi Press Agency. "Foreign Ministry's Makkah Branch Director General Receives Consul General of the Philippines." Template:Cite web</ref>

Hajj Site Inspection

In May 2025, Consul General Romato led the Philippine Consulate General's Hajj Team — together with National Commission on Muslim Filipinos Hajj Attaché OIC Omar Mandia — on an on-site inspection of the Mina and Arafat pilgrimage sites in Makkah.

It was the **first such inspection led by a Philippine Consul General in Jeddah in recent years**, signaling a more hands-on, personal approach to ensuring the safety and comfort of Filipino pilgrims during Hajj.<ref>Department of Foreign Affairs. "PH Consulate General in Jeddah Inspects Hajj Sites to Ensure Filipino Pilgrims' Safety." 16 May 2025. Template:Cite web</ref>

Later that month, Romato was also among those who welcomed the first batch of 376 Filipino pilgrims arriving in Madinah for Hajj 2025, greeting them alongside Ambassador Raymond Balatbat and other Philippine government officials.

Filipiniana Cultural Exchange

In November 2025, in celebration of Philippine Book Development Month, the Consulate partnered with King Fahad Public Library and the National Commission for Culture and the Arts (NCCA) to mount **Windows to the Philippines: Stories, Culture, and Art Through Books** — a Filipiniana book display at King Fahad Public Library in Jeddah.

Romato personally turned over the curated collection from the Consulate's Sentro Rizal library to Dr. Abdullah Alahmadi, CEO of the library, making Philippine literature, art, and culture accessible to Saudi and international readers in both the male and female sections of the facility.

Legacy

Romell Ariman Romato's career is a study in what representation can look like when given room to grow.

He entered the Philippine foreign service as a Meranaw from Marawi — already carrying the distinction of being the first Muslim to lead the UP Diliman student government — and has since built a record of diplomatic achievement that serves not just his community but the entire Filipino diaspora.

His years in Riyadh were defined by the kind of unglamorous, high-stakes work that rarely generates recognition: negotiating deployment terms, managing labor disputes, coordinating presidential logistics, following hostage leads to Yemen, and laying the groundwork for energy and trade agreements that will outlast his tenure.

In Jeddah, he's brought that same seriousness to the welfare of Filipino pilgrims and the broader cultural relationship between the Philippines and the Kingdom.

He's also a living argument — made quietly, through a career, not through a speech — that Muslim Filipinos belong not just in the margins of national life but at its center.

Personal Life

Romato is married to Dr. Nizhreen Mapandi-Romato, a physician.

They have four children.

References

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Categories

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